



Spectacular spokes

At first, wheels were **solid disks of wood**. They worked, but they were very heavy. Around 2,000 BCE, someone in **western Siberia** came up with the bright idea of using spokes inside the wheels to replace the solid wood. They were **LIGHTER AND FASTER**. Metal hubs used with greased axles made wheels turn even more smoothly.



By the way...

It was Neolithic (late Stone Age) people like me who first invented the wheel. We also developed farming and made of stone.

It takes far less energy to turn the axle than to turn the wheel.

How it changed the world

Wheels allowed people to travel and trade much more easily than ever before, and a few thousand years later, wheels were moving faster and farther than ever thanks to the engine. Wheels are also the driving force behind countless useful machines.

Did you know?

The oldest wheels ever discovered are on a stone toy. It dates from 5500 BCE and was found in Turkey.

The Americas

The wheel **wasn't big** in the Americas—the only ones found there are on children's toys. This is probably because there were no animals strong enough to pull carts, like oxen or horses. The people there **had to wait** until these animals, and the wheel, were introduced to them in the 16th century. Until then, the most useful animal they had was the **LLAMA**.



SPINNING WHEELS, used to turn plant material or wool into thread, are probably an **INDIAN INVENTION**, from around the 11th century.



WHEELS really began to motor from the 1700s, at first under steam power and later using **GASOLINE ENGINES**.

